

CHRISTOPHER'S

Davey

BOOK

A PERSONALIZED STORYBOOK

CHRISTOPHER'S DAVEY BOOK

RAMBLEBOOK

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ABOUT THIS DRAFT

Christopher's Davey Book is a working draft, produced with RambleBook from an original story idea. It is complete as a story — beginning, middle, and end, in 6 chapters — and deliberately unfinished as a book. Chapter One is written at full weight; the chapters that follow are leaner, the way first drafts are: the bones and the heartbeat, waiting for a writer's second pass. Writing is rewriting. This is the draft you rewrite from.

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Chapter 1

A Roof with Opinions

Davey swung onto the lowest branch and shuffled sideways to make room for me.



“Found it,” he said.

“You said that about the last place.”

“The last place had ants.”

“So does this place.”

“These ants can stay outside.”

Beyond the tree stood two big rocks with a narrow space between them. From our branch, the gap looked just wide enough for two people who didn't mind occasionally bumping elbows.

We climbed down and clambered over the lower rocks. Davey dropped into the gap.

"Headquarters," he announced.

I sat beside him. The rocks blocked the breeze. Above us was a long strip of blue sky.

"Needs a roof."

"Obviously. Otherwise it's just sitting."

We gathered fallen sticks and laid them across the gap. Then we piled up leaves and spread them over the sticks. Davey handled construction. I handled passing things and saying, "That one's going to fall."

Most of them did.

Eventually, though, we had shade.

Davey brought out an orange.

"Lunch?" I asked.

"Drink first."

He made a little hole in the bottom, held it over his mouth, and squished. Juice dribbled out. He caught most of it.

"That orange has a leak," I said.

"Useful feature."

Only after squeezing out the juice did he peel off the skin. He offered me a piece of the squashed fruit.

We leaned against our rocks and ate. I could imagine staying there all day, with no particular job except being there together.

Then something tickled my ear.

A leaf.

Another landed on Davey's knee.

We looked up.

The middle stick sagged. Davey raised one hand, as if he could politely ask it to stop.

The roof settled onto our heads.

For a moment, neither of us moved.

"Well," Davey said from underneath the leaves, "the shade works."

I lifted a corner.

"Needs a few adjustments."

Davey pushed the roof off his hair.

"Tomorrow," he said, "we do research."

Chapter 2

The Research Department

Davey brushed a corn leaf aside and stepped along the path between the rows. I followed, letting the leaf slide past my shoulder.



For a while, neither of us said anything. The corn rustled overhead. Our footsteps made small, dusty sounds.

This was better than having a roof on your head.

"Maybe we need more roof," I said.

Davey stopped and looked back.

"The amount that fell on us seemed plenty."

We kept walking. Without the shelter in front of us, it was easier to think about it. Unfortunately, thinking had not yet produced anything useful.

Later, we found the others working on a parked car. Its engine was off and its hood was up. Davey went straight over.

"Need a hand?"

Someone passed him a rag. Soon he was wiping tools and handing over the ones they asked for. I helped line them up so we could find them again.

Davey liked being part of the work. He listened closely, leaned in for a look, and asked questions.

Then he studied the rod holding up the hood.

"That's doing a lot," he said.

"It is," I agreed.

"Our roof didn't have anything helping it in the middle."

At last, research.

By afternoon, the ice cream man had arrived. Davey chose a Bomb Pop. I chose a Fudgsicle, and we sat down to discuss our discovery.

"We could put a support right here," Davey said, drawing in the dirt with his free hand.

"Wouldn't that be where we sit?"

He moved the line.

A brown drip landed beside it.

“Your Fudgsicle has an opinion,” he said.

His Bomb Pop began running toward his fingers.

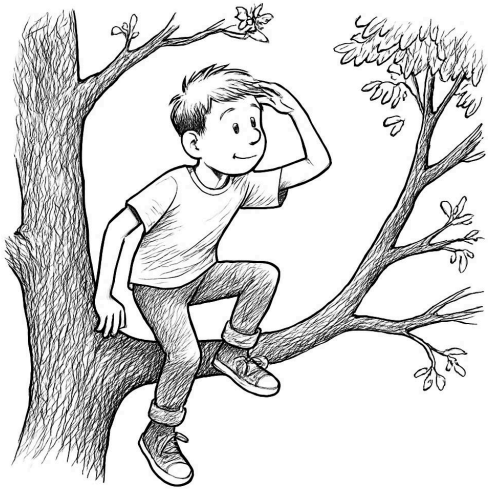
We stopped planning and ate quickly.

The research department had discovered something else: you could take your time thinking, but not with ice cream.

Chapter 3

The Wind Inspector

Davey planted one foot on the low branch and pulled himself up. I climbed after him, stopping where I could see our shelter without being quite so close to it.



From above, the problem looked worse.

One end slumped. The other stuck up. The whole thing seemed to be leaning away from responsibility.

"Crooked," I said.

Davey tipped his head.

"Still crooked," I told him.

We climbed down and clambered over the rocks to inspect it. Davey lifted a loose piece of the old roof.

"Let's start again."

That was the happy part. We knew how to gather sticks. We knew how to pile leaves. Soon we had two heaps and the excellent feeling that we were getting somewhere.

I carried armfuls while Davey sorted.

"Too short."

I put one aside.

"Too bendy."

Another went beside it.

"Just right."

"Should I introduce you?"

He took the stick and grinned.

We laid the stronger pieces across the gap, trying to give each one a steady place to rest. Then we turned toward our leaf pile.

A gust reached it first.

The top layer lifted, skimmed along the ground, and spread into a long, sliding trail.

Davey lunged after a handful. I chased another. Every time I bent down, something scooted past my fingers.

"Like the pond!" I called.

That made him laugh.

In winter, on the frozen pond in New Jersey, we had gone skating together with cold cheeks and flying feet. Sometimes one long glide felt as though it might carry us clear across the afternoon.

These leaves were having that sort of day.

We stopped chasing and watched the last few tumble away.

Davey held up the three he had caught.

"Good news. We've saved enough roof for one ear."

Above our heads, the bare sticks rattled.

Chapter 4

Leave a Little Give

Davey held out a wrench, and one of the others reached for it without looking away from the parked car.



“Thanks.”

We had come to help again. The engine was off, and tools lay within reach. Davey worked beside the

others, pleased to have a job that somebody needed done.

I passed him a rag.

He crouched to wipe a tool, then looked underneath the car and along its low body.

"What?" I asked.

"Our roof's too high."

I waited.

"We keep making a big heap up there. The wind catches it."

He held one hand above the other.

"Lower," he said. "And not packed so tight. Leave some gaps for the air."

"Leave a little give?"

"Exactly."

After we had helped put the tools away and washed our hands, Davey brought out an orange. He made a little hole in the bottom and squished it over his mouth.

I waited while he caught the juice.

"Very serious thinking drink," I said.

He lowered the orange, smiling, then peeled off the skin and shared it.

We sat eating and talked about riding our bikes up and down the street until the streetlights went off. Those rides could make an ordinary evening feel endless.

Then Davey glanced at his shoe.

"Remember that firecracker?"

I did. He had been running down the street without socks while firecrackers were being thrown into the air. One had landed in his shoe, and he had stepped on it.

It had happened so suddenly. Remembering it still gave me a little jolt.

"I want room to get straight out of our shelter," he said.

"No support across the entrance."

"And nothing to trip over."

I drew a doorway in the dirt, wide and clear.

Davey added a lower roof above it.

For once, our plan looked like somewhere we could actually sit.

"Now," he said, "let's build the part we don't bump into."

Chapter 5

Open All Day

Davey pressed down on the edge of the finished roof.



It stayed where it was.

I pressed the other edge.

That stayed too.

We looked at each other, trying not to celebrate before the roof had made up its mind.

Then Davey ducked through the clear entrance and sat between the two big rocks. I followed. Nothing caught my foot. Nothing poked my shoulder.

Above us, the roof rested low and steady, with little spaces where the air could slip through.

"Headquarters," he said.

"Again."

"This time with improvements."

We stayed long enough to discover several important things. There was room to stretch our legs if we took turns. One rock made a better backrest than the other. And a roof that did nothing was much more enjoyable than a roof that did tricks.

Later, we walked through the cornfield.

The path curved ahead of us. Leaves whispered against one another, and sunlight fell in bright patches on the ground.

We didn't need to solve anything.

That felt unusual enough to mention.

"What are you thinking about?" I asked.

"Nothing much."

"Same."

In the afternoon, we visited the ice cream man. Davey got his Bomb Pop, and I got my Fudgsicle. We ate them outside headquarters before they could drip on our sitting places.

Then we went back inside.

A breeze stirred the ground beyond the entrance.

A stronger gust followed.

I stopped with my hand halfway to my knee.

Overhead came a soft rustle. Air slipped through the gaps. The roof shifted just a little, then settled back where it belonged.

Davey looked up.

I looked up.

Nothing landed on either of us.

“Good roof,” I said.

Davey leaned against his rock.

We spent the rest of the afternoon there, giving our excellent roof absolutely nothing to do.

Chapter 6

Headquarters Everywhere

Davey pushed off on his bike, and I pedaled after him.



We rode up the street, turned, and came back down. Our wheels hummed. The evening air cooled our faces.

There was no race unless one of us suddenly decided there was.

Davey moved ahead.

"Oh, is it a race now?" I called.

"Not if you're winning."

I pedaled harder.

We passed each other, slowed, turned, and did it again. After a whole summer of finding things to build and places to sit, going back and forth was still enough.

We rode until the streetlights went off.

On that last summer evening ride together, we talked about headquarters.

"Think the roof misses us?" I asked.

"It probably likes the rest."

We left our shelter as it was. It didn't need another room, a taller roof, or a complicated improvement that might fall into our laps. It had given us exactly what we wanted: somewhere to spend a day together.

Then the seasons changed.

By winter, the New Jersey pond was frozen, and we were skating on the safe, solid ice with the others.

Davey pushed away in a long glide. I followed, arms spread, our blades making crisp scratches beneath us.

The cold nipped my cheeks. Davey turned in a wide curve, and I tried to follow his track.

For a few bright moments, we moved side by side.

"This would make a terrible roof," I said, looking down.

"Excellent floor, though."

We laughed and glided farther.

Headquarters had been a place between two rocks. But I knew the feeling here too: Davey beside me, a whole afternoon ahead, and something worth doing even if we hadn't decided what it was yet.

Davey pointed toward an open stretch of ice.

"Shall we?"

We pushed off together, with no roof required.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

RambleBook makes storybooks about the people you love, from the details only you know.

A storybook to keep & share

Davey is 12 years old. A keepsake storybook about Davey, made for Christopher to keep, to show, and to read aloud.